

## Voice and tone - In-Product

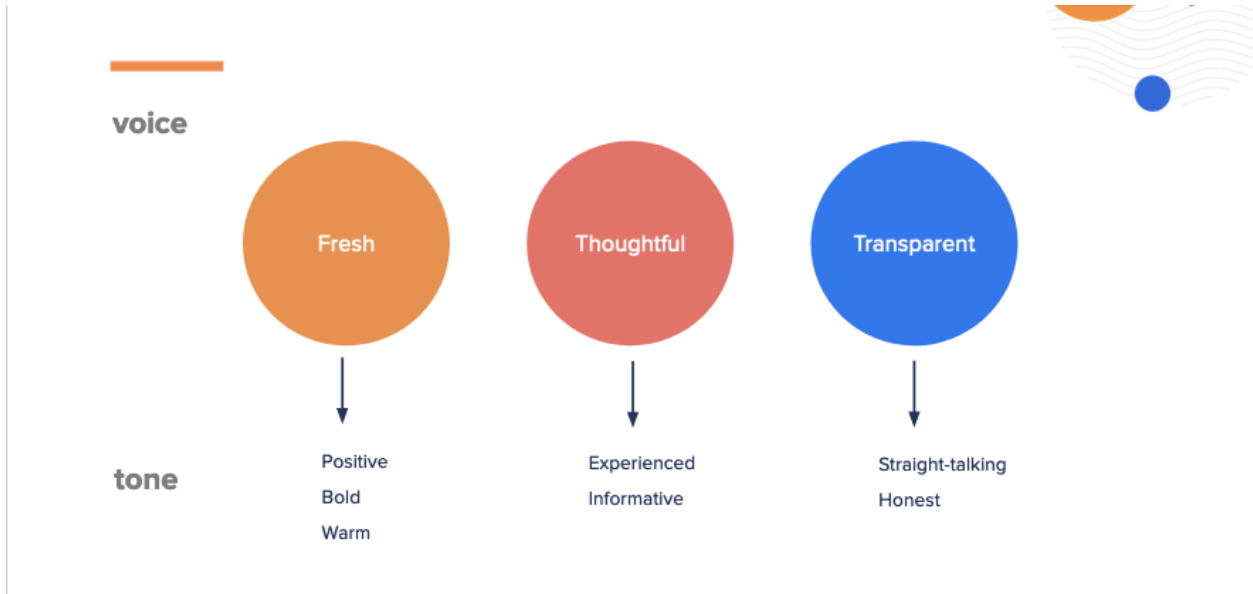
# Voice vs. Tone

Voice is who you are - it stays the same always, but your tone changes. You might use one tone when with friends, but another when with colleagues. You would speak differently when someone is upset versus when they're happy.

In a product, tone makes your voice context-aware. It changes depending on the situation, the reader, and the user's emotional state. The ideal brand voice has to be supported by a range of tones that give it depth. These tones allow the product to adapt to different scenarios and emotional states. Our voice doesn't change much day-to-day, but it's okay to adjust and change our tone as needed always.

## Voice

Marketing is full of confusing terminologies and is a fast-paced field. As such, we speak like the new-age experienced business partners who've got our users back.



When writing, we are:

- **Fresh:** Being experienced doesn't mean we need to be dated. We're partners to young, modern professionals who are looking to get their job done. When speaking to them, we take on a positive, bold, and warm tone of voice.
- **Thoughtful:** Being experienced doesn't mean that we need to be formal, stiff, or show off our technical knowledge and expertise. We value every word we say to our users and help them out as needed.
- **Transparent:** Users need to trust our product when they're looking to get the job done. This means when talking to them, we give the information they need first (front-load), own up to our mistake when something goes wrong, and be clear when helping them out.

## Tone

## who we are (and who we are not)

|                              |            |                                                                    |
|------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| User's<br>emotional<br>state | Pleased    | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Positive and bold</b> , not a “bro”    |
|                              | Excited    | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Warm</b> , not over-friendly           |
|                              | Calm       | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Informative</b> , not stiff or formal  |
|                              | Neutral    | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Experienced</b> , not a technical nerd |
|                              | Uncertain  | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Straight-forward</b> , not blunt       |
|                              | Frustrated | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Honest</b> , not over-explanatory      |
|                              | Angry      |                                                                    |

Tone spectrum

### Positive and bold (not a “bro”)

We want to sound human and be conversational, but not be over-friendly. Use contractions and everyday words.

*Do this:* Your campaign report is ready.

*Don't do this:* Check out your campaign report here.

### Warm (but not over-friendly)

Just because we're not a “bro” doesn't mean we can't pat our users on their back when something goes right or for a job well done. We want to delight our users during their **micro-moments** - after they reach the goal. Be kind and quietly playful. Avoid exclamation marks, and don't be jumpy. Never let style get in the way of meaning.

*Do this:* File saved, nicely done (or) **All done!** The campaign looks good. Hit publish when ready to go.

*Don't do this:* Your campaign is ready to send! Hit publish, and let's do a happy dance (or) Loading your campaign in a jiffy!

## **Experienced (a technical nerd)**

We don't assume users understand technical terms. We try to describe what a feature does (or doesn't) instead of using engineering-speak.

*Do this:*

*Don't do this:*

## **Informative (not stiff)**

We make our writing relatable by using contractions such as "we're not" and "we are." We're not robotic or very formal with users.

## **Straight-talking (not blunt)**

Keep the most important information at the front — don't make users dig for the details they need. When something is wrong, tell the user how they can fix it first.

## **Honest (not over-explanatory)**

We are honest and direct, not passive. When something goes wrong, we say, “we made a mistake,” not “a mistake was made.” We don’t deflect responsibility by using a passive voice.

## Active vs. Passive Voice

The two grammatical voices are **active** and **passive**. **Active voice** means that a sentence has a subject that acts upon its verb. **Passive voice** means that a subject is a recipient of a verb’s action. When the subject of a sentence performs the verb’s action, the sentence is in the *active voice*. Sentences in the active voice have a strong, direct, and clear tone. Below are some short and straightforward examples of active voice vs. passive.

- Active: Marti logged into the account. (Correct)
- Passive: The account was logged into by Marti. (Incorrect)

All three sentences have a basic active voice construction: subject, verb, and object. The subject in each sentence is performing the action of the verb. In product copy, active voice illustrates authority and confidence.

Use passive voice only when active voice sounds stiff or forced.

## Person

The level of formality should be determined by the expectations of the audience and the purpose. Although second-person is acceptable, whenever possible, use **third-person** and avoid the use of the pronoun “you.”

Third-person is used when discussing the product or its features, while second-person is used for instructions.

*Note:* Don't write, "The product allows you to create multiple user segments." Instead write, "The product provides the ability to create multiple user segments."